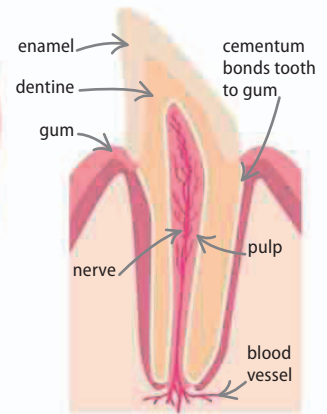
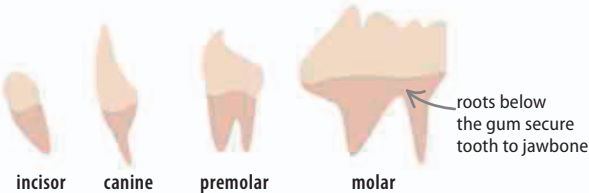
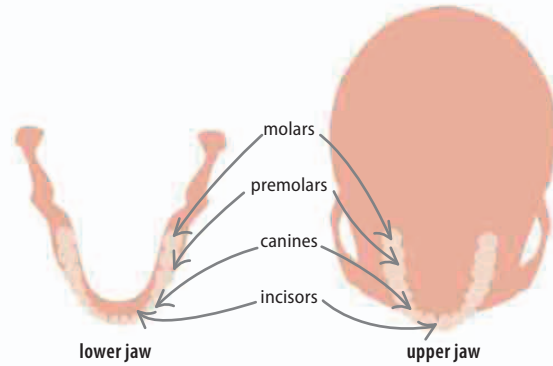


Teeth

Digestion, the breaking up of food into simpler substances that can be used by the body, follows feeding. The first phase of this is often mechanical digestion, where hard, sharp teeth bite food into small chunks or chew it to a pulp. Some toothless animals, such as birds, grind their food internally in gizzards—muscular stomachs that use stones swallowed by the animals to help break up the food.

▷ Human teeth

Humans have four types of teeth. Incisors are used to slice and bite, and canines grip and rip. Molars and premolars are flat and are used for grinding food.



△ Tooth anatomy

A hard enamel cover is supported by softer dentine beneath. The pulp contains blood and nerve connections.

Types of consumer

Not all animals eat the same foods, and that difference is reflected in their teeth and jaws. Carnivores eat meat, so their teeth are often structured to help catch prey and rip it to shreds. Plant food is very tough, so herbivores (plant-eaters) use wide, grinding teeth to make it more digestible. Omnivores have teeth suited to a mixed diet of both meat and plants.

▽ Hunter or hunted?

Scientists can tell a lot about the way an animal lived by the shape, position, and condition of its teeth.



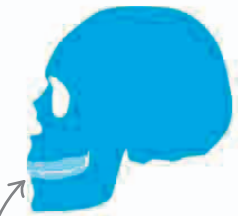
dolphins have many hooked teeth for gripping slippery fish, so they do not escape



lions have long fangs for gripping prey, while large premolars at the back of the jaw slice meat with a scissor action



the gap in a cow's teeth allows the animal to grab a new mouthful of grass while still chewing the last one



human teeth are adapted to a varied diet of fruits, hard seeds, and flesh

▷ Rumination

Chewing food once is not enough for large herbivores, such as cattle or antelopes. They regurgitate food, called cud, from the stomach to chew it a few more times during digestion. Ruminants rely on bacteria living in their complex stomachs to break down the tough cellulose (the main part of plant cell walls) in their food.

